

The Paper Guide: Which Papers Produce The Best Results

The same stroke looks completely different on washi, rice paper, sumi paper, and practice paper. This guide shows you exactly what to expect from each.



One stroke, four papers — and four completely different results.

In sumi-e, the paper is **half the brush**. The same loaded stroke will bloom soft and feathered on one sheet and stay razor-crisp on the next — before you change a single thing about your hand. Learn what each paper does, and you choose your result instead of being surprised by it.

WHAT'S INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- ◆ Washi, rice, sumi, and practice paper — the same stroke compared side by side
- ◆ Where to source the best papers for under \$5 a pack, online and locally
- ◆ How to prep each paper so the ink sits even and strokes come through crisp
- ◆ The best paper for each technique, for the strongest, most vivid result

The Four Papers, Side by Side

The very same brushstroke, painted on each paper in turn. Look at the edges — that is the paper talking, not the brush.



Washi

WARM IVORY



Rice Paper

COOL WHITE



Sumi Paper

SOFT WHITE



Practice Paper

BRIGHT WHITE

Washi — *warm ivory*

The most absorbent of the four. Ink sinks into the long handmade fibres, so every stroke gains a soft, feathered halo. Wet strokes bloom outward — atmosphere comes free, but your timing has to be sure.

ABSORBENCY

High

BLEED

Soft halo

BEST FOR

Mood & atmosphere

Rice Paper — *cool white*

Thin and quick to drink the ink. Strokes land fast, dark, and even, with a gentle, controlled bleed. The dependable all-rounder — at home for both practice and finished work.

ABSORBENCY

Med-high

BLEED

Gentle, even

BEST FOR

Everyday painting

Sumi Paper — *soft white*

Purpose-made for ink painting. Balanced absorbency — bite enough to hold a crisp edge, give enough for smooth graded tone. The most predictable sheet, and the easiest to control.

ABSORBENCY

Balanced

BLEED

Controlled

BEST FOR

Graded tone

Practice Paper — *bright white*

Lightly sized and least absorbent. Ink sits on the surface, so strokes stay sharp and dark but flat — little bleed, little gradation. Built for drilling form, not for mood.

ABSORBENCY

Low

BLEED

Minimal

BEST FOR

Drilling strokes

Where To Source — Under \$5 A Pack

Good sumi-e paper is cheap. These three buys cover every paper in this guide and leave change in your pocket.

1 Practice Paper Roll — *the cheapest way to log hours*

A long roll or thick pad of sumi-e practice paper is the lowest-cost paper you can buy. Tear off as much as you need and never feel precious about a practice stroke.

LOOK FOR Yasutomo Sumi-e Practice Paper (roll or 100-sheet pad).

BUY IT [amazon.com](#) > “Yasutomo sumi-e practice paper”

PRICE about \$3–5 a pack

2 A Rice / Sumi Paper Pad — *your everyday sheet*

A bound pad of rice or sumi paper, 30 to 40 sheets, is the workhorse for real paintings. One pad lasts weeks and stays well under five dollars.

LOOK FOR Yasutomo or Bee Paper “Sumi / Rice Paper” pad, 9×12 in.

BUY IT [amazon.com](#) > “sumi rice paper pad”

PRICE about \$4–5 a pack

3 Washi & Mulberry Sheets — *for finished work*

True washi costs a little more, but small mulberry-paper packs and single washi sheets still come in around five dollars — save them for pieces you mean to keep.

LOOK FOR “100% mulberry paper” sheet pack, or single washi sheets.

BUY IT [amazon.com](#) > “mulberry washi paper pack”

PRICE about \$4–5 a pack

Buying local? The cheapest rice and sumi paper of all is at Daiso and Asian stationery shops — bookstores like Kinokuniya often sell pads for as little as \$1.50. For washi and mulberry sheets, try the fine-paper aisle at Blick or any art-supply store.

How To Prep Each Paper

A minute of preparation is the difference between ink that sits evenly and ink that pools, beads, or fights the curl.

FIRST, FOR EVERY PAPER

Always work over a **felt underlay** — it cushions the sheet and drinks the ink that soaks through. Weight or tape the corners so nothing shifts mid-stroke, and test one stroke on a scrap from every new pack before you commit.

Washi

Never pre-wet it — it is absorbent enough already. Smooth it perfectly flat and weight the top edge. Mix your ink a touch thicker than usual so it holds its shape instead of flooding into the fibres.

Rice Paper

Find the right side: one face is smoother than the other — paint on the smoother side. It is thin, so lay a spare sheet underneath as backing, and weight all four corners.

Sumi Paper

It usually arrives rolled. Flatten it first — press it under books for an hour, or gently back-roll it — or every stroke fights the curl. Then weight the corners; no pre-wetting needed.

Practice Paper

If the ink beads on the surface, wipe the sheet once with a barely-damp cloth and let it dry — that breaks the sizing. Stacking a few sheets also lets the ones below pull the ink through more evenly.

Then let it dry flat. Lift finished work by two corners and lay it flat to dry — never hang it, or the wet ink will run and the sheet will cockle.

PART FOUR

The Best Paper For Each Technique

Match the paper to what you are painting and the result gets stronger on its own — no extra skill required.

Daily practice & the basic strokes

PRACTICE PAPER

Cheap and crisp — drill bamboo leaves and orchid strokes by the hundred without counting the cost.

Crisp lines, branches & fine detail

RICE PAPER

Fast, dark, and controlled; thin lines stay sharp and never flood.

Graded washes & bokashi shading

SUMI PAPER

Balanced absorbency holds a smooth gradient from black to pale grey without blotching.

Atmosphere — mist, distance, wet blooms

WASHI

The feathered bleed is the effect; let the paper do the soft work for you.

Finished & exhibition pieces

SUMI / WASHI

Predictable control for the careful passages, or washi's glow for atmospheric ones.

THE ONE RULE TO REMEMBER

When in doubt, reach for **sumi paper**. It is the most predictable of the four and flatters almost every technique — the safe choice while your hand is still learning. Save washi for the days you want the paper to surprise you, and practice paper for the days you simply want the miles.

Choose the paper first, and half the painting is already right.